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Spicer Suggests, In New Book, Changes In Arlington County Governmental Relationships (The Daily Sun, 17 December 1951, p. 5)

[The Daily Sun, Arlington, Virginia, Monday, 17 December 1951, p. 5. Only the article headed "Spicer Suggests" is reproduced, as Virginia Chronicle's text layer gives it, with plain OCR slips corrected (for example "cour.ty" for "county"); a column break and an advertisement run through it on the page and are left out.]

Spicer Suggests, In New Book, Changes In Arlington County Governmental Relationships

George W. Spicer, Virginia University political science professor, indicates in his new book that he would approve of legislative proposals to change the relationship among the Arlington County Board, county manager and department heads. Prof. Spicer's book, "Fifteen Years of County-Manager Government in Virginia," brings up to date his previous book, "Ten Years of County Manager Government in Virginia."

The County Board's Advisory Committee on Government Organization and Procedure and the Arlington Civic Federation have recommended introduction of legislation that would give back to the county manager the power to appoint department heads, but that would make the county manager's tenure at office indefinite. At present the county manager must be given a one-year contract and 60 days notice if his contract is not renewed.

Arlington's state legislators, Senator Charles R. Fenwick and Delegates J. Maynard Magruder and George Damm, have not endorsed the recommended changes, but plan to introduce bills that would provide referenda on the changes.

On January 27, 1951, the board took over from the county manager the power to appoint department heads, and this action was upheld by Judge Walter T. McCarthy in an Arlington Circuit Court test.

"It is difficult to conceive of such an arrangement as this operating without conflict and irresponsibility," says Prof. Spicer. "The manager can exercise no effective control over department heads without some voice in their selection and removal. In such

circumstances, could not the manager, if he chose, by-pass the heads of department and deal directly with those officers appointed by him?

"Yet there is some plausibility in the position of the board, since the manager is not subject to removal at their pleasure, as he would be under a thorough-going manager plan."